

Anti-Inflammatory Diet for Arthritis — What to Eat for Happier Joints

Discover the best anti-inflammatory foods for arthritis, a sample 3-day Mediterranean-style meal plan, foods to avoid, and joint-friendly supplements.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Can what you eat really make a difference to your arthritis? The honest answer is yes — but not in the way the internet often promises. There is no "miracle food" that cures arthritis. What the evidence does show is that a consistent, balanced, anti-inflammatory way of eating can help reduce background inflammation, support joint health, and improve overall wellbeing. This guide is based on published research and NHS dietary advice — not fads.

How Diet Affects Arthritis Inflammation

Inflammation is your body's natural defence response. In rheumatoid arthritis, the immune system drives inflammation that attacks the joints. In osteoarthritis, inflammation plays a smaller but still meaningful role in pain and tissue damage. Certain foods contain compounds that can either **promote** or **calm** inflammation: highly processed items, refined sugars, unhealthy fats, and excess red meat can increase inflammatory markers, while fruits, vegetables, whole grains, oily fish, nuts, and olive oil contain antioxidants and healthy fats that help reduce inflammation. Diet is not a replacement for medication — especially in RA. But it is a powerful tool to use alongside your treatment plan.

The Mediterranean Diet and Arthritis (Evidence Summary)



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If there is one diet for which the science is strongest, it is the Mediterranean diet. This is not a strict "diet" in the slimming sense — it is a traditional way of eating common in countries like Greece, Italy, and Spain. A 2018 review published in *Rheumatology International* found that following a Mediterranean diet reduced pain and improved physical function in people with osteoarthritis. Studies in rheumatoid arthritis have shown it may reduce disease activity and inflammatory markers. The diet is rich in polyphenols (plant compounds with antioxidant effects), omega-3 fatty acids, and fibre. It includes plenty of vegetables and fruit, whole grains, legumes, oily fish (at least twice a week), olive oil as the main cooking fat, nuts and seeds, and limited red meat, processed foods, and sugary items.

Top 15 Anti-Inflammatory Foods

- Oily fish (salmon, mackerel, sardines, herring) — Rich in omega-3 fatty acids proven to reduce inflammation.
 - Extra virgin olive oil — Contains oleocanthal, a compound with effects similar to ibuprofen (though much milder).
 - Broccoli — Packed with sulforaphane, an antioxidant that may slow cartilage damage.
 - Spinach and leafy greens — High in vitamin E and other antioxidants.
 - Berries (blueberries, strawberries, raspberries) — Rich in anthocyanins that reduce inflammatory markers.
 - Cherries — Particularly tart cherries, shown to reduce gout attacks and inflammatory markers.
 - Turmeric — Contains curcumin, a powerful anti-inflammatory. Combine with black pepper to boost absorption.
 - Ginger — Shown in studies to reduce pain and inflammation in osteoarthritis.
 - Garlic — Contains diallyl disulphide, which may limit pro-inflammatory proteins.
 - Walnuts — High in omega-3 (ALA type) and antioxidants.
 - Flaxseeds — Good plant source of omega-3.
 - Green tea — Rich in polyphenols and antioxidants.
 - Whole grains (oats, brown rice, quinoa) — Fibre helps reduce C-reactive protein (CRP), an inflammatory marker.
 - Beans and lentils — High in fibre and antioxidants; excellent protein source reducing reliance on red meat.
 - Dark chocolate (70%+ cocoa) — Contains flavonoids with anti-inflammatory properties. A small square — not the whole bar.
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Foods That May Worsen Inflammation



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No food needs to be banned forever. But reducing these may help: highly processed foods (crisps, biscuits, ready meals), sugary drinks and sweets, refined carbohydrates (white bread, white pasta, pastries), red and processed meats (burgers, sausages, bacon), fried foods, excess alcohol (no more than 14 units per week), and omega-6-heavy oils (corn, sunflower, soybean) used in processed foods — these may promote inflammation when not balanced by omega-3.

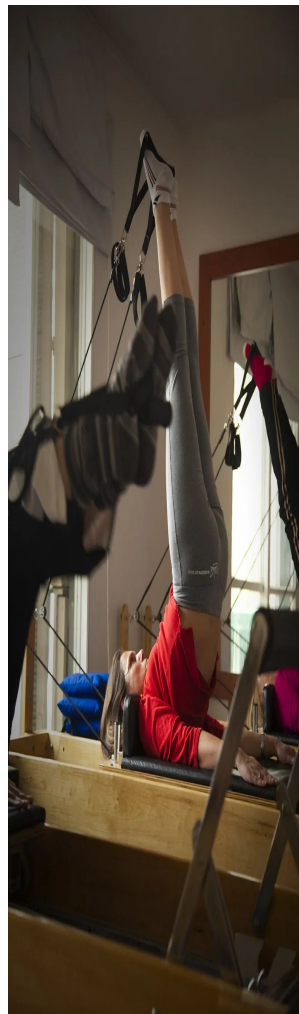
A Sample 3-Day Anti-Inflammatory Meal Plan

Day 1: Breakfast — porridge with oats, semi-skimmed milk, blueberries, and walnuts. Lunch — wholemeal pitta with hummus, cherry tomatoes, and spinach, plus an apple. Dinner — grilled salmon with roasted Mediterranean vegetables drizzled with olive oil, with brown rice. Snack — a small handful of almonds.

Day 2: Breakfast — Greek yoghurt with strawberries, flaxseeds, and a drizzle of honey. Lunch — lentil soup with wholemeal bread. Dinner — chicken and vegetable stir-fry with ginger, garlic, and turmeric, served with quinoa. Snack — a square of dark chocolate (70%+).

Day 3: Breakfast — scrambled eggs on wholemeal toast with grilled tomatoes, plus green tea. Lunch — mixed bean salad with olive oil and lemon dressing, plus rocket. Dinner — mackerel fillets with steamed broccoli and sweet potato wedges baked in olive oil. Snack — cherry tomatoes or carrot sticks.

Supplements That Support Joint Health



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Food first — supplements second. **Omega-3 (fish oil)** has strong evidence for reducing inflammation in RA. **Vitamin D** is important for bone health — the NHS recommends everyone in the UK consider a 10mcg vitamin D supplement in autumn and winter. **Glucosamine and**

chondroitin have mixed evidence — NICE does not recommend them on the NHS but they are available over the counter. **Turmeric/curcumin** has growing evidence for OA pain relief — look for formulations with enhanced absorption. Always speak to your GP or pharmacist before starting supplements — some interact with prescription medications.

Practical Tips for Changing Your Diet

- Start small. Change one meal at a time. Swap white bread for wholemeal. Add one extra vegetable portion today.
 - Cook from scratch where you can. This automatically reduces processed ingredients.
 - Batch cook. Make a big lentil soup or vegetable curry on Sunday and freeze portions for busy days.
 - Use frozen fruit and vegetables. Just as nutritious as fresh, cheaper, and always available.
 - Read labels. If you cannot pronounce most ingredients, it is probably ultra-processed.
 - Don't aim for perfection. An anti-inflammatory diet is about what you eat most of the time — not every single meal.
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Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about anti-inflammatory diet for arthritis — what to eat for happier joints?

Short answer: Diet does not cure arthritis, but a consistent anti-inflammatory pattern can reduce background inflammation, support joint health and improve wellbeing. The evidence points to a Mediterranean-style approach: more oily fish, vegetables, wholegrains, olive oil, nuts and berries; less red and processed meat, refined sugar and ultra-processed food. This guide is based on published research and NHS dietary advice.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk